THE E-COM UPRISING

From apparel to electronics, e-commerce platforms have opened a whole new world for the Indian customer from the comfort of her home

By SONAL KHETARPAL

THE DRUDGERY

Driving through traffic, sweating for a parking space, jostling for shopping items amid the crush in a shop, finding what you wanted but not the right size, standing in a long queue for payment... Shopping was a nightmare experience for many. Heat, rain and the cold added to the ordeal, as did festivals or discount shoppers. And heaven forbid if you lived in a small town or village where branded wear was alien, or were a price-conscious customer. For the first, you'd have to make your way to the nearest city. For the second, you'd have to physically trudge from outlet to outlet before you found the right thing at the right price. Things did ease up with the arrival of the shopping mall, with everything under one roof, but you still could not escape the crowds, or the time spent on the commute or inside the store.

THE EASE OF LIVING

E-commerce changed all that, and how. It began with the launch of Bengaluru-headquartered Flipkart in 2007 (later acquired by Walmart), which started with selling books online. Gurugram-based Snapdeal followed three years later, in 2010, offering coupons, discounts and exclusive offers; Amazon landed in India in 2013, also as a bookseller. After books, e-commerce platforms turned out to be the perfect marketplaces to sell a modern artefact: mobile phones. "This is because mobile phones were standardised products, and it was easier to read reviews and compare prices online," says Kushal Bhatnagar, associate partner at management consulting firm Redseer.

To reach the untapped millions, online retailers now leverage voice search, local language options, lighter versions of apps



E-commerce websites
Launched in mid-2000s

Achievement: From $0.3 billion (Rs 1,392 crore) in 2009, the e-commerce market grew to $65 bn (Rs 5.4 lakh crore) in 2023. It's predicted to touch $200 bn (Rs 17.3 lakh crore) by 2030

HOW IT TRANSFORMED MY LIFE

"Very convenient to get things delivered home"

Dipti cannot remember when she last stepped into a market. As a working woman and a mother of two children, time is a luxury she has in short supply. Coming to her rescue are the multiple e-commerce websites. For her apparel needs, there's Amazon and Myntra for casual wear, or